Comparison notes:

1. Same cost, different ~~event~~ effort. Both algorithms find the cheapest path. They differ only in how many cells they search.

2. Dijkstra spreads out evenly in all directions by cost so far. A* adds a goal direction guess, so it should search less.

3. A* saved about 31% on map 1* since it leans toward the goal.

4. On map 2, the saving is small. Walls force the path to wind around, so guessing the direction helps little.

5. On map 3 they are identical. The goal is walled off, so neither algorithm can narrow the search, and both must exhaust every reachable cell before reporting no path.

6. Two paths of the same cost can look different. On map 1 the paths have different shapes, because there are several equally cheap routes and the tie-breaking differs.

7. Time is not a reliable comparison here. A* ~~rea~~ even measured slower on map 2 because computing the heuristic cost time. Cells explored is the meaningful measure.

8. A* is guaranteed optimal only with an admissible heuristic. Dijkstra needs no heuristic and is always optimal, but it explores more when the goal lies in a clear direction.